

6.2 EXEMPLAR COURSEWORK TASKS

The following examples are for guidance and are provided to assist candidates and teachers in appreciating the possible nature of investigations. Ethical considerations should be applied in the choice of materials and procedure.

Experimental Method

This involves the manipulation of one variable and the measurement of another.

For example:

An investigation into perceptual set where groups of participants are shown the same stimuli, and the responses of the 'primed' group are compared with the responses of the control group.

An investigation into the effect of chunking on recall.

The serial position curve can be used to demonstrate LTM and STM, as well as primacy and recency effect.

Observational Method

This is the observation of behaviour, which can be either naturalistic or participant, for example:

Observation of seating preference in the school/college cafeteria or library, or a study on door opening behaviour. A checklist of possible behaviours could be drawn up, and the behaviour then noted.

An observation of differences in non-verbal communication in crowded and uncrowded environments.

Naturalistic observation of territorial behaviour in school/college libraries, e.g. placement of books, coats, bags etc.

Correlational Study

This involves measuring the relationship between two variables, for example:

Investigating the link between the type of words recalled from a word list (happy, sad) and the mood reported by the participant.

A correlation between the number of positive reinforcements given during an interview and the rating given to the interview by the participants.

Survey

This is a questionnaire or interview with a representative sample. The interview could be structured or unstructured, e.g. a survey of student hassles. Participants could be given a questionnaire in which they are asked to rate various hassles, e.g. traffic jams, noise, or examinations. The results could be analysed according to age groups and gender.

Candidates may carry out:

A survey on gift choice

A survey on moral development

A comparison of responses between age groups when considering moral dilemmas

Content Analysis Study

This is a useful technique to use if difficulties are experienced finding participants. A content analysis could be carried out on, for example:

The number of stereotypes or gender roles assigned to males and females, (or the number of reverse gender roles and stereotypes observed) in popular television programmes, advertisements, soap operas or magazines.